

Yitong Wang

Department of Economics
Texas A&M University

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Education

Texas A&M University	2022 – Present
Ph.D. in Economics	Expected May 2027
University of International Business and Economics , Beijing, China	2018 – 2022
B.A. in Economics (Honors)	

Fields

Public Economics, International Trade, Macroeconomics

Job Market Paper

“Refund Frictions and the Transmission of Export VAT Rebates” with Li Gan and Siyuan Zeng (2026).

How a tax incentive is paid can matter as much as its size. China’s 2015 export VAT rebate reform delivered the same increase either as an immediate reduction in VAT owed or as a delayed cash refund, depending on firms’ tax positions. Using the National Tax Survey Database and customs data in a triple-difference design, we find that refund-dependent firms expand exports only half as much and show no equipment response. Present-value discounting explains only a small share of this gap; the remaining evidence is consistent with a working-capital friction, as financially tighter firms respond more strongly only when rebates arrive immediately. A calibrated model shows that faster refunds or borrowing against pending claims can nearly eliminate the response gap.

Working Papers

“Optimal Research Contracting with Observable Firm Characteristics.” (2026). *Under review*.

This paper studies how observable firm characteristics can improve public research contracting in NASA’s Small Business Innovation Research program. Patent intensity and past SBIR completion rates predict project completion propensity but receive little weight under the status quo. Under a fixed budget, the optimal OFC mechanism captures 61% of the first-best improvement over pooling by reallocating awards toward projects whose participation and completion decisions are more responsive to funding.

“Should the Government Subsidize Firms or Households?” with Li Gan and Yuzhe Zhang (2024).

Using IMF cross-country COVID-19 subsidy data, this paper studies how governments allocate fiscal support between households and firms. Larger budgets, greater inequality, and more severe outbreaks are associated with a higher household-to-firm subsidy ratio.

“The Optimal Inflation Rate.” with Shenghao Zhu (2022).

This paper derives a sufficient-statistic formula for optimal inflation in a continuous-time heterogeneous agent New Keynesian (HANK) model with idiosyncratic income risk and asset heterogeneity. Calibrated to U.S. wealth data, the model implies an optimal inflation rate of 5.2%.

Presentations

Allied Social Science Associations (ASSA) Annual Meeting, scheduled	2027
Southern Economic Association (SEA) Annual Meeting, scheduled	2026
Texas A&M University Macro Mini Conference	2026
Texas A&M University Macro Mini Conference	2025
North Texas Economics Conference	2025

Teaching Experience

Texas A&M University

Instructor, ECON 410: Intermediate Macroeconomic Theory	Summer 2025
Instructor, Macroeconomics Qualifier Camp (Ph.D.)	Summer 2024
Instructor, Math Camp (Ph.D.)	Summer 2023

Teaching Assistant, Graduate Courses

ECMT 660: Mathematical Economics	Fall 2026, Fall 2025
ECON 689: Special Topics—International Macroeconomics	Spring 2026
ECON 636: Macroeconomic Theory I (Ph.D.)	Fall 2023

Teaching Assistant, Undergraduate Courses

ECON 460: Introduction to Mathematical Economics	Fall 2026, Fall 2025
ECON 323: Microeconomic Theory	Fall 2026, Fall 2025, Summer 2025
ECON 410: Intermediate Macroeconomic Theory	Summer 2026
ECMT 461: Economic Data Analysis	Spring 2025, Spring 2024
ECON 311: Money & Banking	Fall 2024, Fall 2022
ECON 203: Principles of Economics	Summer 2024, Summer 2023
ECON 459: Games & Economic Behavior	Fall 2022

University of International Business and Economics

Teaching Assistant, Advanced Macroeconomics (Undergraduate)	Fall 2020
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Research Experience

Research Assistant for Prof. Li Gan (Texas A&M University)	Summer 2023, 2024
Research Assistant for Prof. Shenghao Zhu (UIBE)	2020 – 2021

Honors, Awards, and Fellowships

Graduate Assistantship, Department of Economics, Texas A&M University	2022 – Present
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Skills

Programming: Python, Stata, MATLAB, C++, $\text{\LaTeX}$

Languages: Chinese (native), English

References

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